Merit Badges

FACT SHEET

Background

Scouts can earn more than 100 merit badges, including the newest merit badges—Game Design, Programming, and Sustainability. Earning merit badges gives Scouts the opportunity to participate in activities and study subjects that prepare them for life. For information on merit badge requirements and resources, go to the following link: http://www.scouting.org/BoyScouts/AdvancementandAwards/MeritBadges.aspx.

Merit Badge Popularity

The top 10 merit badges required for Eagle rank earned in 2013:

- Camping
- Citizenship in the Community
- Citizenship in the Nation
- Citizenship in the World
- Communication
- Environmental Science
- Family Life
- First Aid
- Personal Fitness
- Swimming

The top 10 merit badges not required for Eagle rank earned in 2013:

- Archery
- Art
- Canoeing
- Fingerprinting
- Fishing
- Kayaking
- Leatherwork
- Rifle Shooting
- Wilderness Survival
- Wood Carving

The table below compares merit badge popularity for the past three years by merit badge name. This table also includes the overall count for each merit badge. To date, Scouts have earned more than 117 million merit badges.

Merit Badge	2011	2012	2013	Overall
American Business	707	679	805	52,490
American Cultures	2,965	2,883	2,649	65,595
American Heritage	6,645	6,626	6,195	153,488
American Labor	1,168	811	1,090	21,816
Animal Science	3,759	4,503	4,174	57,035

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Merit Badge	2011	2012	2013	Overall
Archaeology	9,586	10,316	8,913	147,338
Archery	45,204	48,229	43,879	1,560,606
Architecture	3,586	3,631	3,956	212,426
Art	32,146	29,273	28,031	1,283,372
Astronomy	14,941	17,308	16,332	623,496
Athletics	3,411	3,465	3,709	1,061,764
Automotive Maintenance	10,762	10,784	10,084	157,322
Aviation	21,440	20,751	18,330	586,975
Backpacking	4,445	4,878	4,114	210,107
Basketry	23,505	22,073	19,364	2,422,344
Bird Study	6,881	6,952	6,405	576,544
Bugling	628	613	515	169,468
Camping*	62,492	60,772	59,982	4,608,447
Canoeing	41,601	39,042	33,409	2,991,801
Chemistry	9,569	9,692	10,731	339,869
Chess	6,002	29,298	27,315	62,615
Cinematography	7,245	8,308	8,465	100,089
Citizenship in the Community*	57,785	57,951	56,928	3,410,028
Citizenship in the Nation*	64,558	64,120	61,272	3,148,247
Citizenship in the World*	67,779	67,486	64,452	2,207,456
Climbing	24,617	24,609	22,861	393,310
Coin Collecting	7,052	6,043	5,667	491,841
Collections	5,027	5,077	4,966	137,563
Communication*	60,749	59,345	57,111	2,002,047
Composite Materials	1,817	1,610	1,817	11,631
Computers	14,712	14,474	15,149	505,835
Cooking*	23,989	23,384	44,903	4,238,453
Crime Prevention	8,374	8,331	7,274	129,751
Cycling**	6,992	7,053	6,551	568,910

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Dentistry	4,491	4,403	4,213	131,968
Disabilities Awareness	7,503	7,230	6,690	115,272
Dog Care	3,407	3,330	3,351	428,507
Drafting	1,170	1,377	1,440	223,340
Electricity	11,187	11,350	10,968	794,345
Electronics	7,186	8,060	8,753	207,645
Emergency Preparedness***	50,510	51,035	50,153	1,791,260
Energy	3,641	3,907	3,989	76,724
Engineering	9,418	9,682	10,445	134,912
Entrepreneurship	1,895	1,932	1,900	19,946
Environmental Science****	78,719	76,238	71,609	2,645,369
Family Life*	55,812	56,210	55,080	1,110,829
Farm Mechanics	2,627	2,457	2,421	218,316
Fingerprinting	53,189	46,594	45,140	1,630,578
Fire Safety	16,886	14,517	12,988	2,595,257
First Aid*	94,268	92,312	87,477	6,900,983
Fish and Wildlife Management	16,162	15,528	13,411	639,459
Fishing	32,048	31,932	29,788	1,960,830
Fly-Fishing	4,605	4,291	4,690	22,642
Forestry	16,456	16,309	14,874	1,136,480
Game Design	0	0	2,657	2,657
Gardening	2,422	2,258	1,972	385,872
Genealogy	5,452	5,641	5,740	226,164
Geocaching	19,419	18,711	17,031	59,694
Geology	23,695	24,015	22,103	625,840
Golf	5,798	5,128	4,921	162,815
Graphic Arts	3,620	3,505	3,140	47,754
Hiking**	7,946	8,132	7,856	1,322,873
Home Repairs	4,324	4,413	3,790	2,411,304

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Horsemanship	13,814	12,670	10,977	629,814
Indian Lore	28,591	26,705	24,535	1,174,871
Insect Study	3,579	4,120	3,613	161,919
Inventing	2,279	2,592	2,704	8,191
Journalism	1,285	1,184	945	105,427
Kayaking	0	21,765	36,217	57,892
Landscape Architecture	1,475	1,618	1,872	80,215
Law	7,315	7,274	6,946	179,302
Leatherwork	51,535	48,674	44,344	2,404,514
Lifesaving***	29,382	28,228	25,945	3,012,934
Mammal Study	31,028	28,309	24,064	1,171,288
Medicine	4,480	4,507	3,990	68,823
Metalwork	12,790	13,674	13,259	1,121,690
Model Design and Building	2,964	3,120	3,628	217,564
Motorboating	12,133	12,004	11,012	575,590
Music	15,875	15,088	14,223	1,305,854
Nature	18,453	18,114	16,164	1,650,396
Nuclear Science	6,965	7,114	7,666	167,079
Oceanography	10,720	10,636	10,769	278,355
Orienteering	20,221	18,989	16,909	800,270
Painting	5,087	5,412	4,911	557,778
Personal Fitness*	56,588	56,908	56,295	2,448,534
Personal Management	53,459	54,529	53,273	1,763,687
Pets	6,068	5,904	5,659	653,842
Photography	18,042	18,879	17,800	487,705
Pioneering	23,138	21,550	19,525	2,395,091
Plant Science	2,614	2,593	2,712	42,121
Plumbing	6,417	5,785	5,178	386,396
Pottery	10,493	10,157	9,869	374,901

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Programming	0	0	480	480
Public Health	1,989	1,783	2,006	1,515,824
Public Speaking	6,703	6,987	7,289	635,412
Pulp and Paper	6,449	7,495	7,034	108,357
Radio	6,257	6,957	7,208	165,817
Railroading	9,144	8,681	7,191	230,661
Reading	5,889	5,676	5,216	1,478,332
Reptile and Amphibian Study	9,816	9,772	8,483	640,555
Rifle Shooting	54,276	50,435	47,054	1,282,140
Robotics	5,407	13,262	13,401	32,070
Rowing	15,906	13,769	10,944	1,707,281
Safety	4,128	3,824	4,349	2,931,236
Salesmanship	6,765	6,425	6,438	318,182
Scholarship	6,570	6,310	5,956	1,271,352
Scouting Heritage	6,407	5,394	5,660	21,275
Scuba Diving	3,015	2,594	2,370	11,071
Sculpture	13,074	12,829	11,493	292,521
Search and Rescue	0	725	10,552	11,277
Shotgun Shooting	27,838	26,173	24,603	496,310
Skating	3,208	2,220	2,406	171,350
Small-Boat Sailing	19,895	18,740	16,857	635,798
Snow Sports	10,586	8,636	9,134	442,991
Soil and Water Conservation	15,554	14,553	11,697	1,110,949
Space Exploration	23,595	23,557	23,290	537,246
Sports	9,167	9,112	8,950	1,137,357
Stamp Collecting	1,147	1,045	1,131	388,644
Surveying	1,145	1,235	1,307	150,583
Sustainability****	0	0	590	590
Swimming**	80,938	80,376	72,946	6,242,264

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Textile	3,657	4,681	4,673	139,316
Theater	2,201	2,776	2,320	81,389
Traffic Safety	8,665	7,450	7,582	150,483
Truck Transportation	3,009	2,928	2,847	135,395
Veterinary Medicine	3,502	3,460	3,455	73,210
Water Sports	4,783	4,291	3,935	246,460
Weather	18,582	17,869	15,958	562,112
Welding	0	4,022	10,919	14,941
Whitewater	4,322	4,149	3,252	84,887
Wilderness Survival	46,757	46,829	43,158	1,594,933
Wood Carving	45,645	44,927	41,120	2,248,909
Woodwork	5,590	4,962	5,602	966,728
TOTAL	**2,164,366**	**2,175,878**	**2,110,848**	**117,288,535**

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New Merit Badges—Youth Interest Survey

The Research & Program Innovation Department surveys Boy Scouts and parents of Boy Scouts to gather interest and feedback on upcoming merit badges. Feedback from previous Youth Interest surveys has been used in development of recent merit badges including: Robotics, Chess, Welding, Kayaking, and Search and Rescue. Youth Interest surveys are sent to current Scouting Youth Panel and Parents of Boy Scouts Panel members. To join the Scouting Youth Panel or the Parents of Boy Scouts Panel, go to: http://scouting.org/about/research/ResearchPanel.aspx.

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